

IMPACT REPORT



# COOL/ SCARY AI SH!T

DC Summit · October 29, 2025

FROM THE ORGANIZERS

# Hello,

Welcome to the impact report from Cool/Scary AI Sh!t DC, held on October 29, 2025 at the Martin Luther King Jr. Memorial Library in partnership with DC Public Libraries. On a Wednesday afternoon in the nation's capital, we brought together nonprofit professionals, technologists, advocates and community members for four hours of honest conversation about what AI means for the social impact sector — and for the people it serves.

This was our first DC event and our largest speaker lineup to date: thirteen voices spanning civic tech, digital inclusion, accessibility, advocacy, organizational readiness, grant funding, media literacy, and the case for a publicly owned AI. The range was intentional. AI's impact does not stay inside neat categories, and neither should the conversation about it.

What made this event distinct was its setting. Libraries are one of the last true third spaces — free, open, and designed for belonging. The library was not just a venue; it was a statement about who gets to be in the room when AI's future is discussed.

We publish these reports because we believe the voices in rooms like this one deserve to be part of the broader record. AI's rules are being written right now. We intend to make sure they are not written without us.

Onward,

**Ben Childers and Chelsea Kirkland**

Cool/Scary AI Sh!t x DC Public Libraries



# SESSION HIGHLIGHTS

Ben Childers

**HEAD OF EXPERIENCE DESIGN, COOL/SCARY AI SH!T — DIGITALLY INVISIBLE**



Introduced Dr. Nicole Turner Lee's concept of digital invisibility — a shift from the inputs-based digital divide to an outcomes-based understanding of who is actually seen, valued and served. Through the story of a day laborer who cannot work after the 20th of the month because his prepaid minutes run out, Ben grounded the day in the lived realities of people already being left behind.

Cameron Peltz

**DC CIVIC TECH — A PITCH FOR CIVIC TECH**



A volunteer-driven nonprofit bringing together technologists, project managers and community members to build tools for social good: an algorithm that scrapes eviction notices and texts legal aid resources to affected residents, data visualization for voter suppression cases. Start with the problem, build collaboratively, design tools reusable across organizations.

Chelsea Kirkland

**DIGITAL INCLUSION COORDINATOR, DC PUBLIC LIBRARIES — PLACEMAKING**



Digital inclusion is not just broadband or devices — it is the spaces where people gather, learn and build belonging. She highlighted DCPL's AI Upskilling Cohort, in which 50 recently laid-off knowledge workers spent twelve weeks building AI-powered projects in small groups at the library, culminating in demos at DC Startup and Tech Week. If digital invisibility is the new divide, placemaking is the bridge.

Tom Spencer

**CO-FOUNDER, ADVOCACY AI — IN NEED OF A PUBLIC FOUNDATION MODEL**



A provocative argument for publicly owned foundations for large language models. He polled the room on trust in tech leaders — not a single hand went up for one of them — and used AI-generated images throughout as a deliberate demonstration of how current models reflect a narrow view of the world. For roughly \$100 million, a fraction of what has been invested in private tech companies, we could build a public model that speaks in the voices of the people whose data created it.



## SESSION HIGHLIGHTS, CONTINUED

Ira Horowitz

### CORNER SHOP CREATIVE — BEYOND ALT TEXT

A practical session on using AI to make websites accessible: the four WCAG principles, and the four places nonprofits most commonly fall short — HTML markup, PDFs, captions and transcripts, alt text. He demonstrated audit plugins, AI-powered PDF remediation, auto-captioning and a bulk alt text generator, and warned against overlay widgets that claim to fix accessibility automatically: they often interfere with assistive technology and have faced lawsuits.

Cat Proulx

### BEEKEEPER GROUP — AN AI USE POLICY PEOPLE WILL ACTUALLY USE

Attendees mapped their own AI use on a compass grid, then compared it to where their colleagues and organizations think they are. The misalignment was visible across the room. She walked the essentials — purpose, scope, users and overseers, devices and accounts, and how much use is permitted — and argued that responsible internal policy is a prerequisite for credible advocacy on AI legislation.

Jeff Livingston

### AI-FUELED CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

Pushed back against both hype and doom for a pragmatic, iterative approach. Drawing on Charity Water's quarterly beneficiary outreach and Khan Academy's monthly feedback loops, he argued nonprofits of any size can move from annual review cycles to continuous improvement with tools they already have. The key insight was cultural, not technological. His practical tip: ask your AI for a veracity score on any analysis it produces.

Chris Lundberg

### CEO, ENGINE 9 — YOUR NEXT ENGINEER IS A PROMPT

Walked through vibe coding, retrieval-augmented generation, Model Context Protocol and AGI. He showed a non-technical staff member building a functional donor lookup app in 20 minutes, and painted a near future where a conversational interface replaces the traditional CRM entirely. He closed with a frank acknowledgment that AI will take jobs and will not give them back — but argued the technology itself is neutral, and what matters is who holds it.



## SESSION HIGHLIGHTS, CONTINUED

Laura Rodriguez

**GLOBAL WAVE DIGITAL — HOW AI IS CHANGING ADVOCACY**

AI Access for All provides training to civil society organizations from Kenya to the Philippines to Colombia. A survey of partners found 78% reported little to no familiarity with AI tools, while 100% believed AI was valuable and wanted training. She highlighted a Kenyan partner whose communications person also serves as legal advisor — a common reality for under-resourced groups — and insisted access must be equitable, culturally sensitive and grounded in the communities served.

Craig Johnson

**UNFILTERED MEDIA — A CASE STUDY FROM LOCALIST**

A four-person nonprofit in rural Wisconsin working to get clean energy permitted discovered that LLMs are among the most effective deprogramming tools available. Building on research showing people are more persuadable by AI than by humans — because the interaction does not trigger the filters that shut down political persuasion — they introduced a chatbot that engages opponents with cited sources and patient dialogue. The result: 30% conversion rates in rural communities.

Patty Debow and George Danilovics

**PTKO — CLOSING THE READINESS GAP**

Three scenarios familiar to many nonprofits: the rebel in the ranks already using AI independently, the rogue board member who came back from a weekend excited and told IT to make it happen, and the C-suite champion with budget and ambition but no roadmap. For each, a practical response. Their core message: AI adoption is a change management project and deserves the same rigor as any other major initiative.

Dr. Tatiana Warren

**SOCIAL BEHAVIORAL SCIENTIST AND GRANT REVIEWER — MILLION DOLLAR MISTAKES**

A sharp warning about AI in grant writing. Grant management systems now use detection tools to reject proposals exceeding 60% AI-generated content, and human reviewers are catching hallucinated citations — fabricated authors, invented publications. She cited a \$500,000 impact report found to contain AI-hallucinated citations attributed to real researchers who never wrote the cited works. Use AI to learn and draft, but do your due diligence.

Cameron Peltz

**DC CIVIC TECH — AI LITERACY IN ACTION**

Closed the programming with a media literacy crash course: how generative models work, their sycophantic tendency to produce relevant rather than truthful output, and examples of AI-generated propaganda and manipulated media. Practical detection strategies — visual artifacts, account histories, corroboration across sources, responsible sharing. Everyone in the room has the power to amplify or guard against false information.



# THEMES AND PATTERNS

## Ownership and agency are the defining questions

The most persistent thread was not what AI can do but who controls it and who benefits. The call for a publicly owned foundation model, placemaking as a path to digital agency, and the Localist case study all circled the same question: in a world where AI is trained on our collective data, who decides what it does with that data? The room's answer was consistent.

## Accessibility is a practice, not a checkbox

Overlay widgets that claim to solve accessibility in one click often make things worse — and the principle extended beyond web design. Building spaces where people feel safe to learn, ensuring training is culturally and linguistically appropriate, and the event's own design all reflected accessibility as an ongoing practice

## Start with what you have

The continuous improvement framework, the readiness scenarios and the policy checklist converged on the same practical wisdom: you do not need a massive budget or a dedicated AI team to begin. Use the LLM you already have, the CRM you already pay for, the governance processes you already follow. The barrier is cultural, not technological.

## Human oversight is necessary but insufficient

Nearly every speaker stressed keeping humans in the loop. But several pushed further: oversight alone is not enough if the humans doing the overseeing do not understand the technology. Skill-building and critical literacy are preconditions for meaningful oversight, not nice-to-haves alongside it.

## The cool and the scary are not separate categories

The event's name proved to be its most accurate description. The same LLM technology flooding the internet with misinformation is also the most effective deprogramming tool nonprofits have. A non-technical person built a working app in twenty minutes — exciting and destabilizing in equal measure. AI-generated images illustrated AI's biases while arguing for public ownership. Cool and scary are not a spectrum; they are the same thing viewed from different angles.



# WHAT ATTENDEES SAID

Nine attendees completed the post-event survey. A small sample, but their responses reinforce the themes and point toward what this community wants next.

## LIKELIHOOD TO ATTEND AGAIN

# 4.67

out of 5. Two-thirds gave the highest possible rating, and no respondent rated below a 4. The most frequently cited value was the diversity and range of perspectives represented.

“Diversity of voices. There are a lot of events in fundraising and technology, and a lot of the same people flock to said events. This event had a different feel.”

“Closing the gap between ambitions and readiness. Too many orgs just want to do AI — they provided a strong approach to making progress.”

## Sessions that resonated

Respondents named nearly every session as their standout, with no single talk dominating — the AI use policy, accessibility, vibe coding, the public foundation model, readiness, continuous improvement and the Localist case study. The spread confirms that breadth was a feature, not a bug.

## What they want next

Deeper technical dives into tools and infrastructure; real-world case studies and practical applications; and the environmental impact and sustainability costs of AI. Several asked for more on ethics and panel-style discussion. Seventy-eight percent expressed some interest in a working group.



WITH THANKS

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## CORNERSHOP CREATIVE

A digital marketing agency supporting nonprofits and small businesses with website design, development, hosting and digital marketing.



## BEEKEEPER GROUP

A digital public affairs firm in Washington, DC specializing in strategic communications and advocacy.



## ADVOCACY AI

Works with nonprofits, trade associations and community groups to strengthen advocacy efforts using AI.



## STRATOVATION PARTNERS

The organizational design and growth consultancy that produces the Cool/Scary AI series.

## VENUE PARTNER



The Martin Luther King Jr. Memorial Library served as both venue and co-host. Special thanks to Chelsea Kirkland, whose vision for the library as a space for community-driven AI learning made this partnership possible.

## COOL/SCARY AI

A national series of community-centered conversations about AI's real impact, produced by Stratovation Partners.

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